



WhatsApp app or WhatsApp Business Platform?

What each one does, what you actually pay Meta since per-message pricing started, and why answering customer enquiries is mostly free. Plain English, no jargon, every rule linked to Meta's own pages.

1. Two different products

	WhatsApp Business app	WhatsApp Business Platform (API)
Cost to use	Free to download.	No fee to Meta for replies to customers inside 24 hours. Some template messages are charged per message (see section 2). A provider or developer usually charges for set-up and hosting.
Who replies	Your staff, on a phone (plus linked devices).	Software you connect: an assistant, a CRM or a shared inbox for several staff.
Built-in automation	Greeting message, away message, quick replies, labels, catalog.	Anything you build: instant answers 24/7, lead qualification, hand-over summaries to staff, reminders.
Best for	One or two people answering a manageable number of chats.	Enquiries arriving after hours or faster than staff can answer; teams; connecting to bookings or CRM.
Account	On the phone that owns the number.	A WhatsApp Business Account in your company's own Meta Business portfolio.

App features from WhatsApp's small-business guide. If you are still on a personal WhatsApp account, moving to the free Business app is step one: our free *24/7 WhatsApp Enquiry Playbook* covers it.

2. What Meta charges on the Platform

Since **1 July 2025** Meta charges **per message** (it used to charge per 24-hour "conversation"). Messages fall into four categories:

Category	What it is	Charged?
Service	Normal replies to a customer who messaged you (text, images, documents).	Free , while the 24-hour customer service window is open.
Utility	Templates about an existing transaction: booking confirmation, reminder, order update.	Free inside an open 24-hour window; charged outside it.
Marketing	Templates that promote: offers, re-engagement, newsletters.	Always charged.
Authentication	One-time passcodes for login or verification.	Charged (volume discounts apply).

The 24-hour window. When a customer messages you, a window opens for 24 hours from their latest message. Inside it you can reply freely. After it closes you can only start again with an approved template, and templates can be charged.

Free entry points. If the customer reaches you from a Click-to-WhatsApp ad or a Facebook Page call-to-action button, and you reply within the window, all messages for the next **72 hours** are free, templates included. (The ad itself is paid separately.)

Rates. Prices depend on the customer's country code and category, and Meta bills in 15 currencies including AED. Meta raised the UAE marketing-message rate on 1 October 2025 and updates rate cards periodically (latest effective 1 July 2026), so always take today's number from Meta's official rate card rather than a blog: business.whatsapp.com/products/platform-pricing. Volume tiers lower utility and authentication rates at high monthly volume.

3. Why an enquiry assistant costs little in Meta fees

An enquiry assistant mostly **answers people who wrote first**. The customer opens the 24-hour window, so the answers, the qualifying questions and a booking confirmation sent in that window are all free Meta messages. Meta fees only appear when your business starts or restarts a chat:

Situation	Meta fee?
Customer asks a price at 23:40; assistant answers and collects details	None (service, in window)
Staff confirm the booking the next morning, within 24 hours of the customer's last message	None (in window)
Reminder template the day before an appointment, sent after the window closed	Utility rate
"Still interested?" follow-up to a quote that went quiet for a week	Marketing rate, in most cases
Monthly offer sent to past customers who opted in	Marketing rate per message delivered

Estimate your own Meta bill (formula, not a quote)

Monthly Meta fees $\approx$ (marketing templates delivered $\times$ UAE marketing rate) + (utility templates sent outside the window $\times$ UAE utility rate) + (authentication templates $\times$ rate).

Replies to customers inside 24 hours add nothing. Look up the rates on Meta's rate card for "United Arab Emirates" in your billing currency. This is an estimate; your provider may add its own mark-up.

4. AI on WhatsApp in 2026: what is allowed

From **15 January 2026** Meta's WhatsApp Business Solution terms bar AI providers from distributing **general-purpose** chatbots (open-ended "ask me anything" assistants) through the Platform. Meta said businesses using AI to serve their own customers are not affected, for example a travel company running a customer-service bot. In practice: an assistant should answer about **your** business, services, prices and bookings, and hand anything else to a person. That is exactly how Mountain AI builds assistants.

5. Can we keep our number on the app?

Often yes. Meta's "coexistence" onboarding lets a number stay on the WhatsApp Business app (version 2.24.17 or newer) while it is also connected to the Platform through a provider, so staff keep chatting from the phone while the assistant handles the rest. Trade-offs Meta lists: broadcast lists become read-only, disappearing and view-once messages are turned off in 1:1 chats, some companion devices are unsupported and throughput is capped. Meta does not list market availability on that page, so we confirm it for your number before any pilot.

6. Quick decision checklist

Stay on the free app (use our playbook) if...	Consider the Platform if...
Most enquiries arrive while staff are free to answer.	Many enquiries arrive evenings, Fridays or during rush hours.
One or two people handle WhatsApp.	Several staff or branches share one number.
Quick replies cover your common questions.	Staff repeat the same qualifying questions all day.
You rarely lose a booking to a slow reply.	You suspect enquiries go cold before anyone answers.

7. See it before you decide

Free demo in 24 hours → 14-day pilot → full setup

Send us your website. Within 24 hours you get a private link to a working enquiry assistant built only from your public information. Test it on your phone. If you like it, run it live for a **14-day pilot (AED 1,500 fixed, credited in full if you continue within 30 days)**. Full setup is AED 7,500 + AED 1,250/month. Meta message fees are billed to you directly by Meta or your provider. We don't promise a number of bookings; the pilot report shows what actually happened.

WhatsApp +971 56 777 3366 (reply DEMO) · **info@mountainai-ae.com** · mountainai-ae.com/pilot.html

Sources (checked 29 Sep 2026)

- Meta for Developers, "Pricing on the WhatsApp Business Platform": per-message pricing from 1 July 2025, categories, 24-hour window, free entry points, 15 billing currencies, UAE marketing rate change 1 Oct 2025, rate cards effective 1 July 2026. developers.facebook.com/documentation/business-messaging/whatsapp/pricing
 - WhatsApp Business, platform pricing and official rate cards. business.whatsapp.com/products/platform-pricing
 - WhatsApp Business, "How small businesses can use the WhatsApp Business app" (free app; profile, catalog, greeting/away messages, quick replies, labels). whatsappbusiness.com/resources/resource-library/small-business-use-whatsapp-business-app/
 - Meta for Developers, "Onboarding WhatsApp Business app users" (coexistence requirements and limitations). developers.facebook.com/documentation/business-messaging/whatsapp/embedded-signup/onboarding-business-app-users
 - TechCrunch, "WhatsApp changes its terms to bar general-purpose chatbots from its platform", 18 Oct 2025 (effective 15 Jan 2026; Meta statement on business customer-service bots). techcrunch.com/2025/10/18/whatsapp-changes-its-terms-to-bar-general-purpose-chatbots-from-its-platform
- Meta's rules and prices change. This guide is general information, not legal or financial advice. WhatsApp and Meta are trademarks of Meta Platforms, Inc.; Mountain AI is not affiliated with Meta.